

Council Meeting

April 9, 2025

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Contemporaneous meeting notes for use with other resources in preparation of draft minutes
MEMBERS – PERSONS appearing – BRIEF DESCRIPTION – DECISIONS. RSA 91-A:2.

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, April 9, 2025, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Girard at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne
Ward II Councilor Brian Zutter
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Hayden
Assistant Mayor Debora Matteau
At-Large Councilor William Greenrose
At-Large Councilor Wayne Hemingway
At-Large Councilor William Limoges
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Mayor Dale Girard

Also present:

Yoshi Manale, City Manager

AGENDA CHANGES

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to suspend council rules to add an agenda item.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – no

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-1

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MEMBERS – PERSONS appearing – BRIEF DESCRIPTION – DECISIONS. RSA 91-A:2.

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to add a Non-Public Session RSA 91-A:3, II(c) after future agenda items.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes
Greenrose – yes
Limoges - yes
Matteau – yes
Zutter – yes
Hemingway – yes
Hayden – yes
O’Hearne – yes
Girard – yes
Motion carried 9-0

REPORT OF THE SECRETARY

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Limoges to accept the minutes of the March 26, 2025, City Council meeting.

Councilor Hayden stated he voted no at the motion to accept the last set of minutes; all were in favor of the change.

Voice vote:

Koloski – abstain
Greenrose – yes
Limoges - yes
Matteau – yes
Zutter – yes
Hemingway – yes
Hayden – yes
O’Hearne – yes
Girard – yes
Motion carried 8-0

MAYOR’S NOTES

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On April 26th - Moody Park trail day is looking for volunteers, details can be found on the Wheelhouse social media and Parks and Recreation website.

Mayor Girard noted he wanted to read a letter after having a conversation with the City Manager.

In this letter the Mayor noted a number of concerns with the City Manager such as the airport lease being fully executed even though the City Manager stated he did not sign the lease, carrying costs for 17 Water Street building not being fully transparent, concerns in the community like Sullivan Street, performance bonds, bid tabulations not being posted consistently, not using the lowest bidder, sign boards, overspending line items with dramatic increases and stipends being used for special duties for merit employees, and budgets being overspent. Mayor Girard noted growing concerns for recession and fiscal responsibility and thinks the Manager should be required to provide a 2026 budget proposal 5% below the 2025 department budget.

Councilor Koloski stated he wholeheartedly agrees with the Mayors comments this evening, and is in support of asking the manager, and stated if that needs to be a motion from this Council, he would go that route.

Councilor Koloski also stated the City Manager said to him that there would be padding in this budget because the Council needs to feel good about making cuts during the meeting. Councilor Koloski stated this was upsetting and a waste of the council's time and the public's time.

Manager Manale stated he doesn't recall saying this to councilor Koloski and noted this is something he hasn't done in the past.

Manager Manale noted in 2022 the council passed a motion that allows the manager to sign all leases for the airport. Manager Manale also stated the other concerns have been resolved or has tried to provide as much information in regard to these concerns. For paving the city received a contract that came under what the city was expecting from the vendor, so the additional funds were used to do other projects, which is administratively allowed.

Manager Manale had concerns with the suggestion of a negative 5% budget and a request not to have a capital budget from the Mayor. Thinks its unfair to make these deciosons before seeing a presented budget. Manager Manale noted that a minus 5% budget is not a minus five; it's more like a minus 9%. This would be a 1.8-million-dollar budget cut and that means taking away infrastructure, and personnel. Manager Manale stated if asked this is something that will be provided but does not think this is something that needs to be done, the City is growing; there has been 600 new permits this year, new housing, new businesses, paving projects. If the city makes a 1.8 million cut it would be cutting progress and suggests the Council look at a presented budget first as there are opportunities in the budget to find savings

Councilor Koloski stated appreciating the City Managers' comments, but feels the Council has heard these same conversations, and said some things Council asks for is like pulling teeth and understands the City Manager doesn't like the comment made but suggested rolling in a lie detector from the Police Department. Councilor Koloski then stated the comment made him upset and he reached out to Councilor Zutter, Assistant Mayor Matteau, Councilor Limoges, and stated he was cautioning everyone going into the budget to take a look at it with a fine-tooth comb, and noted when the city manager was hired it was presented that Manager Manale was the type who would give the council options for the budget.

Assistant Mayor Matteau also appreciates City Managers comments and agrees with many of them and is happy about the City moving forward.

Assistant Mayor Matteau noted asking for a five-year comparison of the previous budgets and stated consistently, year after year there was about 7% that didn't get spent which is budgeting more than the City needs. Assistant Mayor Matteau also stated citizens got hit with a huge increase, and seeing the office where they pay these bills is now closed one day a week, and that their road hasn't been paved makes them concerned and people are worried about their future.

Councilor Limoges thanked Manager Manale but is also in favor of the 5 %.

Councilor Hemingway agrees that Claremont is moving forward but is looking for transparency and brought up budget cuts from federal and state and how everyone needs to tighten their belt to save taxpayers money.

Councilor Zutter doesn't agree with the 5% number but agrees with tightening our belts and feels there needs to be a positive attitude about the budget.

Councilor Greenrose stated he doesn't want to get into the he-said/she-said , and agrees to cut as much as able, but wants to understand the consequences so the Council can make an informed decision; understanding the numbers is also understanding the impact.

Councilor Koloski noted he had follow up questions.

What is the status of staff time being used for the CDA.

What is the Opera House Balcony status.

What is the status of the installed DPW asset software.

Are there any water meters that have not transitioned to a radio meter.

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What is the Sullivan Street status.

What is the status of the new human resources software, is there a long-term contract.

Bid Processes, and why some bids are not awarded to the lowest bidder.

What are the 17 Water Street total costs.

What is the status of stipends being paid.

Why are we sending the building inspector and other staff for 17 Water Street tours, Are we are taking everyone who calls.

Why are the pickle ball and tennis court meetings continuing.

Wants a more detailed legal report.

What is the succession plan for pool training.

CITY MANAGER'S REPORT

Manager Manale introduced the City's new Human Resource Director, Shannon Thibodeau.

APPOINTMENT TO BOARDS AND COMMITTEES

Conservation Commission

A motion was made by Councilor O'Hearne and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to appoint Eric Ruffin to Seat 3 of the Conservation Commission.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O'Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

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Motion carried 9-0

A motion was made by Councilor Hayden and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to re-appoint Eric Peabody to Seat 6 of the Conservation Commission.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

A motion was made by Councilor O’Hearne and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to re-appoint Eric Zengota Seat A1 of the Conservation Commission.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

Elks Education Fund Trustee

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Councilor Greenrose to appoint Vicki Corliss to Seat A4 the Elks Education Fund Trustee.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

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Greenrose – yes
Limoges - yes
Matteau – yes
Zutter – yes
Hemingway – yes
Hayden – yes
O’Hearne – yes
Girard – yes
Motion carried 9-0

Historic District Commission

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Hemingway to re-appoint Richard Wahlrich to Seat 5 of the Historic District Commission.

Voice vote:
Koloski – yes
Greenrose – yes
Limoges - yes
Matteau – yes
Zutter – yes
Hemingway – yes
Hayden – yes
O’Hearne – yes
Girard – yes
Motion carried 9-0

Planning Board

A motion was made by Councilor Greenrose and seconded by Councilor Limoges to re-appoint Richard Wahlrich to Seat 4 of the Claremont Planning Board.

Voice vote:
Koloski – yes
Greenrose – yes
Limoges - yes
Matteau – yes
Zutter – yes
Hemingway – yes
Hayden – yes
O’Hearne – yes

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Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

Upper Valley Lake Sunapee Regional Planning Commission

A motion was made by Councilor Limoges and seconded by Councilor Hemingway to re-appoint Tom Luther to Seat 1 of the Upper Valley Lake Sunapee Regional Planning Commission.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

Councilor Koloski asked for a review of the tax abatement board, and to look into removals for poor attendance of the Arts and Historic committees.

CITIZEN’S FORUM

Mayor Girard gave reminder that Citizen’s forum is designed to allow you the opportunity to make the Council aware of your concerns. Please state your name and ward number, we ask you to address your concerns directly to the Council. The Council Manager will not be responding to you during this time. You are limited to five minutes on any non-agenda items. In the back of the room please write down your contact information if you’d like to be contacted as well as your concern on the clipboard for follow-up.

Charlene Lovett, Ward II, representing the Sugar River Rotary Club for Cleanup Claremont Earth Day Celebrations from April 22nd to May 4th.

4/25 SHS group litter critters downtown area from 9:30am-12:30pm.

4/27 rotary at veteran’s park from 1:00pm-4:00pm.

5/3 conservation commission boat landing and tractor supply from 8:00am-12:00pm.

Dana McGrath, Ward I, moved here in 2021 on Broad Street because of being inspired the City was investing in the Pleasant Street revitalization project. Hopes the Council will consider those who are also willing to invest by buying homes and creating businesses in this city such as young professionals who want to see Claremont thrive.

Rob Walker, Ward I, wants to provoke thoughts and create shifts of thinking and build a culture of doing something more. Times have changed and a portion of Claremont's institutions and residents haven't caught up to this shift, things have evolved, and the city does too. What can be done to move things forward, doing wrong things more efficiently isn't progress. Is the council focused more on cost instead of value. Mr. Walker asked the Council as they look at their budget ask, are we making peoples lives better and if not be brave enough to change it.

OLD BUSINESS

None.

NEW BUSINESS

Weston and Sampson EPA Presentation

Todd Bridgeo, Weston and Sampson Team Leader and Engineer joined by several teammates Sarah DeStefano, Brownfields Team leader, Jonnathan Law, Senior Team Leader who also lead designer and project manager for the Pleasant Street landscape, and Meghan Gutknecht, landscape designer presented a slide show of conceptual plans for the synergy site and the former Joy Plant site.

Councilor Koloski asked about the grading of the granite benches and if there were any conversations about reversing that grade or the ability for a musical performance.

Mr. Bridgeo noted this is a first concept trying to tick as many boxes, no conversations for individual needs have been had yet.

Dana McGrath, Ward II, noted as a person on Opera House and EPA Steering Committee, doesn't want the venue to be competition and questioned who is going to manage and book these events.

Councilor Hayden clarified if this is a continuation like an add on to the space near the visitors Center, if the upper space will still be there and this is additional. Mr. Bridgeo replied, yes.

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Councilor Koloski had a concern for turf, Mr. Law stated this design is adjustable.

Resolution 2025-39 Capital Reserve and Expendable Trust Fund Review and Cleanup

Director Bates noted this was something talked about at the last meeting, this resolution would establish the revaluation capital and expendable trust funds.

A motion was made by Councilor Hayden and seconded by Councilor Zutter to accept Resolution 2025-39.

Councilor Hayden read Resolution 2025-39 into the record.

Mayor Girard opened a public hearing, no one spoke. Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

New Budget Lines Review Discussion

Director Bates noted this isn’t something typically brought to Council, but the Finance Office has been doing a significant amount of general ledger clean up and proposing to split out department costs for information technology these costs were buried throughout different budgets making it harder to get a handle on what is actually being spent.

FY26 Benefits Cost Review Discussion – Health Insurance and NHRS

Director Bates noted this is just informational to give a sense of cost over time for items because they impact budget.

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Mayor Girard asked if NHRS going down slightly this year, Director Bates replied, yes.

Councilor Hemingway asked if this includes medical. Director Bates is waiting to see what happens with HealthTrust, because analyzing health insurance companies is a big investment in time.

Director Bates also noted the City is offering a high deductible plan which would bring costs down.

FY26 General Liability, WC, and Unemployment Insurance Review Discussion

Director Bates stated this information is important going into the budget process this area of insurance has been steadily increasing over time there aren't a lot of options for municipalities as the city has specific needs, and this information is to keep in mind while going through budget.

COMMITTEE REPORTS

Councilor Koloski reported the Arts Committee has an exhibit at the Visitors Center and received a donation to fund a future project, and the Council will be receiving a letter for end results of inventory.

Councilor Limoges noted the CDAs dealing with water damage and DPW is grading away and discussed realtors to list the CDA property.

Assistant Mayor Matteau noted the Zoning sub-committee did a review for the definition of recovery housing, a video to help explain some zoning amendments and thinks the committee is ready to bring some of these into ordinance form.

Councilor Hemingway reported for Zoning Board that Royce Street requested a continuance, and Liberal Beef docking on was approved.

Councilor Hayden noted the EPA had the same presentation from Weston and Sampson and was expecting a lot more feedback. The Conservation Commission shared clean-up dates and encourages people to sign up.

FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

Assistant Mayor Matteau would like a follow up on class 6 roads.

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Councilor Koloski would like an update on carrying costs for 17 Water Street, and an update on the Mrytle St. bridge clean up.

Councilor Koloski asked when the Sullivan Street change order happened, and what happened to the granite that was pulled out.

Councilor Zutter asked if there were any cuts or building during the Washington st paving.

NON PUBLIC RSA 91-A3 : II (c)

Members of the Council present:

At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski

At-Large Councilor Joel Tremblay

At-Large Councilor William Limoges

Assistant Mayor Debora Matteau

At-Large Councilor Wayne Hemingway

Ward 3 Councilor Jonathan Hayden

Ward 1 Councilor Andrew O’Hearne

Mayor Dale Girard

Motion by Councilor Koloski to enter Non-Public under RSA 91-A:3, II (a) and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

Entered nonpublic at 8:40 PM

Reentered public session at 9:47 PM

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Motion by Assistant Mayor Matteau to seal the minutes based upon this could affect adversely the reputation of any person other than a member of the board. Motion was seconded by Councilor Zutter.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

Motion to adjourn by Councilor O’Hearne and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

O’Hearne – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

These minutes recorded by: Mayor Dale Girard

Respectfully Submitted,

Julia A. Bizzarro

Clerk to the Council